



of

PRESENTATION SKILLS

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of

PRESENTATION SKILLS

A-Z OF PRESENTATION SKILLS

AUDIENCE : When preparing to meet your audience remember never to overestimate their knowledge or underestimate their intelligence. There are a number of key questions to consider as you start to plan your presentation:-

- Who is going to be there?
- Who are my “allies” and who are my “enemies”?
- How can I use my allies before the presentation?
- What can I do to warm up any enemies before the presentation (phone calls, emails, pre-presentation meetings etc)
- How much do they know about my subject?
- How much do I know about theirs?
- What have they each been told about the background to the presentation?
- What is their understanding of my objectives?
- What are their objectives and expectations?
- What information should I send out to people before the presentation?
- Is someone going to introduce me – if so, what will they say?
- What would I like them to say?
- How does my presentation need to be tailored to meet their departmental needs and individual personalities?
- What issues/difficult questions am I likely to encounter?
- How will the decision making process work after the presentation?



BACKWARD PLANNING : The best place to start thinking about your presentation is the end! Start with the end objectives in mind and plan backwards how to achieve them. Three good techniques to help you with this are:-

1. Write down on a piece of paper “As a result of my presentation the audience will be able to.....” Now complete the sentence. This will give you a good feel for what you want the audience to do as a result of your presentation.

Do you want them simply to improve their knowledge? Do you want them to give you an order? Do you want to arouse interest and discussion? Do you want them to change the way they are currently doing things – to stop doing something or do something they haven’t done before. Ask yourself “What is the most important thing here – if I wanted to convince my audience of only one thing what would that be?”

2. Don't write your objectives slide first. Write the last slide first. This will again encourage you to think of your grand-finale ending and picture the outcome you want as you start to hear the applause from the audience.
3. Imagine that a journalist is going to write a paragraph in the newspaper the day after your presentation – what would you want him/her to write? “Tom Williams secures biggest order in the company's history!” or “Tom Williams gives them plenty to think about!” etc. etc.

As a result of your backward planning you will be able to draw up a plan for delivering, preparing and writing your presentation. Good speakers in public are good planners in private. Put your presentation planning dates in the diary and make them happen – if you start to prepare early there will probably be plenty of time to do everything.

If you leave it all until the last minute, it will show. Badly prepared presenters look badly prepared. They lack confidence and look jittery. Presenters who don't know where they are going usually get there.

Never say “I don't have the time”. We all have exactly the same amount of time as Shakespeare, Bill Gates or Marie Curie – our days are “identical suitcases” and are all the same size – but efficient and effective people can pack more into theirs than others. Always find the time to plan effectively.

“If I had eight hours to chop down a tree I would spend six hours sharpening my axe!”
Abraham Lincoln

CONTENT: During the weeks preceding your presentation write down, in any personal shorthand you wish, any facts and ideas you can think of. Don't write sentences – at this stage you are just searching your mind for ideas – not writing a speech. If you are familiar with them, mind maps are also a useful way of collecting ideas.

Later, when trying to decide what to put in and what to leave out of your presentation, you may like to put your suggestions and possibilities into one of three columns on a piece of scrap paper – things your audience must know, things they should know (if there is time) and things they could know (if you are well ahead of time). Time pressure may determine, often on the day, what you decide to put in and what you decide to leave out.

Imagine that you are going to deliver a customer presentation featuring a new product – when planning the presentation the three categories might look like this.....

Things they <u>must</u> know	Things they <u>should</u> know	Things they <u>could</u> know
Why the product was introduced The features of the new product and how it compares to other products on the market The benefits of the new product – i.e. the value it will add to the customer's business	How the product has benefited customers similar to them	The detailed story behind the research and product development Press comments

When planning the content some presenters use “post-it-notes” on a piece of flip chart paper and move them around three “must/should/could” columns– this allows them to reflect on the content possibilities as the presentation starts to take shape.

Good presentations are not packed with masses of information. They cover a low number of high-impact points not a high number of low-impact points. Oddly enough, the more you say the less they will remember.

Give your “must knows” plenty of space so that they don’t get lost in a lot of waffle and trivia. Think of your “must knows” as a photograph – leave plenty of room for a wide mount and wide frame to create the space needed for the best result.

Another good structure for a customer presentation where you are trying to win the business is the “pentathlon” below:-

Position: the background

Problem: what it is, how it occurred, damage it is causing

Possibilities: a number of possible solutions to test the water i.e. “we can help you solve the problem in three different ways depending on your budget and the time it will take”

Proposal: after some discussion you firm up your proposal and talk specifics

Payback: what the customer will get from your proposal – their return on investment.

DIFFERENT ROOM LAYOUTS: We are all familiar with the phrase “horses for courses” and this also applies to presenters and the room layouts they use. The best layout is the one you want to use, not necessarily the one you are presented with.

Ask yourself the question “*Which room layout is best suited to help me achieve my objectives?*” Once you have a clear view of this you can proactively take steps to influence the room layout – including the room layout at a customer’s premises.

There is a golden rule here – don’t use the layout you are presented with, try and choose or influence the layout and create the environment you want.

You may also like to think of football and the high number of teams that win when they play at “home” rather than “away”. Ask yourself the questions “Am I playing at home? Should I do the presentation at our office rather than the customer’s? Rather than play away from home in a hostile environment could I play at a neutral venue? (like a hotel half-way between the customer’s premises and our office).

RISKS	ROOM LAYOUT	OPPORTUNITIES
“Naughty boys at the back” Lecturing Poor visibility at the back	Classroom 	Can take large numbers OK for “testing” people Good access up the aisles
Lack of control Poor visibility for some Over-competitiveness	Island 	Brainstorming/Problems Encourages teamwork Good access to all
Poor access to people Can't issue handouts It is a one-way layout	Theatre 	Ideal for product launches Can take large numbers Visibility – banked seating
Has two blind spots Not good for 20+ “Tunnel Effect”	U shape 	Excellent for training Good visibility for all Very close contact
Difficult to use projector Too intimate for some Can be free-for-all	Round table 	“All in this together” Conflict/problem solving Openness and intimacy
Difficult to see presenter Difficult to use projector Lack of involvement	Boardroom 	When power is needed Control through the chair “I’ve made it”

EQUIPMENT and VISUALS: When using visual equipment there are some “do’s and don’ts” that are worth noting:-

Power-point projector

- Avoid too many slides i.e. “death by power-point”
- Your slides should not be your script
- Don't repeat every word on the screen
- Use pictures/graphs etc
- Put in blank slides to draw attention back to you
- Avoid a succession of 5-6 bullet point slides
- No more than one slide per minute
- Use 36-40pt as a minimum

Overhead projector

- Locate OHP at desk height
- Locate the machine away from spotlights – the darker the better
- Put slides on machine before you switch it on
- Keep table top tidy – have a pile of slides to be shown and another pile for slides that have been used
- Use the slow reveal technique with a piece of card – have a 50p coin ready to put on the card to stop it slipping off the last couple of inches
- Make sure the full OHP picture is on the screen and that you are using the full potential of the machine
- Don't look at the screen – use a pen as a pointer on top of the projector
- Turn off the machine when you have finished referring to a slide – don't leave an old slide up as it will become a distraction

Flip chart

- Alter legs to right height
- Locate the flip under a spotlight – the brighter the better
- Don't stand in front of it – put your arm around the back to restrict your movement
- If you are right-handed the flip chart should be on your left
- Use strong colours only – red, blue, green and black
- Put pens upside down in a mug so that ink falls to the nib ends
- When you have finished turn over and leave the audience looking at a blank page
- Use capital letters, coloured asterisks and underline with squiggly lines not straight lines
- When taking audience feedback always write down their actual words – it is very flattering

Remember the golden rules of working with pieces of equipment:-

1. If it can break, it will break.

2. Always have “Plan B” ready. If your projector breaks be prepared to carry on and issue handouts. Have them prepared – if things go smoothly you could always use them as summary handouts at the end of your presentation so your hard work will not be wasted.
3. If you are using someone else’s equipment make sure that you book it and confirm your booking by email
4. If you are taking your own equipment check that it is working
5. If a colleague offers to book some equipment ask them to send you a copy email of their booking
6. Have your own bag of flip chart pens, acetate pens, blu-tack, screwdrivers etc – don’t assume that they will be at the venue.

EMPATHY: Empathy is the art of “being one of the audience” and seeing things from their point of view. It is about being able to live in their world and understand their problems and issues.

Sometimes presenters get off to a terrible start, without realising it, by making what can only be described as a “smart remark” that distances them from the group
e.g.

1. “When I used to do your job some years ago.....”
2. “I was in LA only last week.....”
3. “When I had lunch with your MD the other day.....”

If you want to enjoy the full support of your audience try and stay at the same “level”. Use your genuine knowledge and expertise to impress them rather than using your superficial “seniority” and position.

FLYING STARTS: Presentations are like aeroplanes – at their most dangerous when they take off or land! The first, and last, two minutes are crucial.



1. Calming Nerves – someone once said that the human brain is a marvellous piece of equipment that works well from the moment we are born to the moment that we stand up to speak in public. Fortunately there are many techniques for dealing with nerves although presenters still need “butterflies” to get the best results.
 - Rehearse the first minute in your mind twenty times and in front of a colleague until s/he gives you the “thumbs up”. Excessive pauses, filled with “errh” and “you know” are almost always a sign of insufficient rehearsal.
 - Never start until you are ready – even if it means saying “just talk amongst yourselves for a minute whilst I get set up”. This is not going to be a problem for

the audience because someone will probably want to make a quick phone call or go to the loo!

- Have a glass of water handy to keep your mouth moist
- Establish good eye contact with a friendly supporter in the room.
- Try deep breathing before you start – it will slow your heart rate dramatically.
- Stand with your feet eighteen inches apart – if you stand with your feet together you will sway and resemble the leaning tower of Pisa!
- Try and get a visual up quickly – a slide with your objectives perhaps. The group will look at it, not you, and you will calm down very quickly
- Sit down and cover an item of “any other business” before you start e.g. “Could I just check the timings before we start.....” or “Could I just get the introductions out of the way before we start our presentation.....” or “Can you hear me at the back? When you then stand up to do your presentation your heart rate will be back to normal and you will feel confident but calm but remember that this “AOB” start could be perceived as a weak opening.

“The day I lose stage-fright is the day I stop acting!”

Laurence Olivier

2. Your objectives slide – don’t crowd it with masses of detail. Keep it simple for best effect – three objectives will be remembered and four won’t. State your objectives in their terms not yours.

Example: Don’t say “*My objective is to explain what the Marketing department does*” try saying “*My objective is to explain how Marketing intends to help you generate £500k of new business during the next three months.*”

Tailor your language and try and use a tailored visual that is built around your audience’s needs. The language on the slide should also be “theirs” not yours.

A bore is someone who talks to the audience about himself.

A gossip is someone who talks to the audience about others.

A good presenter is someone who talks to the audience about themselves!

3. Motivate your audience – early on in your presentation they will have a very personal, selfish agenda. They will be thinking “What’s in this for me? Why should I bother to listen to this?” You can motivate your audience in many ways:-
You could start your presentation by saying something the audience never expected to hear. The surprise will grab their attention.
Asking a question – but be prepared for the unexpected answer. If you say “Has anyone ever had a near fatal accident?” you need to know what you are going to say if they all put their hands up.
Using a positive motivator that explains the benefits e.g. “We think that the solutions outlined in our presentation today will save between £40-£50k next year.....”

Using a negative motivator that explains the consequences of not going ahead e.g.
“Towards the end of our presentation we will outline the financial benefits of our proposal but perhaps I could just repeat something that James said at the first meeting.....we need to do something radical because if we don’t we will have to make 20% of our people redundant!”

4. Signpost your presentation The audience at the start of a presentation are like horses before the start of a race – scattered all over the place and facing in different directions. The starter has to bring them all up to the line together so that they start level and all go off in the same direction at the same time. As part of getting off to a flying start try “signposting” – this technique tells the audience where you are taking them, what lies ahead and how you want to work with them e.g.



1. *“My presentation will last for forty minutes and is split into three sections.....”*
2. *“Here is our proposal. We would like to give you some time to read the first section, then take your questions before we present sections two and three.....”*
3. *“During the next hour please ask questions as we go along.....”*

You can use this signposting technique throughout the presentation, not just at the start e.g.

4. *“I am now coming to one of the most important parts of my presentation.....”*
5. *“We’ve just got time to cover section three, then we will have a quick coffee, then we will show you the film.....”*
6. *“Before I summarise, let me give you a chance to ask some more questions...”*

5. Time your presentation – set your watch at 12.00 the moment you are due to start. This way, every time you glance at your watch you will quickly know how many minutes you have been talking for.

So here is the overall summary of this “Flying Start” section – handle and channel your nerves, get three objectives up on the screen quickly, use tailored language and images, motivate the audience (both positively and negatively) and signpost what you intend to cover during your presentation.

GESTURES AND MOVEMENT: Most audiences like to see the presenter moving around from time to time using hand gestures to illustrate a point. Watch the “Magnus

Pike” hands though, the coins or keys in the pocket, playing with the revolving pencil and standing with your hands crossed in front of you – you will look like a nudist!

Remember to smile and engage with peoples’ eyes – it will relax the audience, give them confidence in you and suggest that they are about to listen to something enjoyable.

You can also use your open arms to encourage participation and input but if someone asks a difficult question don’t fold your arms as it looks defensive. Keep your hands at waist level – don’t hold them in front of you as it will look as if you are praying.

GRAVEYARD SHIFT: Straight after lunch your audience will be ready for a quiet siesta. Something will be needed to encourage them to tune in to your presentation – try and select a topic for discussion rather than simply talking to them. If it is a hot day you may need them to physically move about.



Also, and as part of your preparation, if you are one of a number of presenters scheduled throughout the day and you have been given a midday slot assume that the timings will overrun and that you will get the “graveyard shift”. Be prepared, once again, to amend your plan.

HICCUPS AND COCK-UPS: There will always be the occasional hiccup, things out of your control, that will happen during your presentation. For example a fire alarm going off, crashes and bangs outside, someone entering the room with a message for a member of your audience or a mobile phone ringing.

Although it is tempting to jump in and say “Not to worry, as I was saying.....” try to reverse this technique and get the group to recap. Scratch your head, look a little lost and say “Where was I?” Now the group will have to do the work, distancing themselves from the distraction or disturbance in the process.

Cock-ups are things that are within your control. Here are some examples:-

1. You forget your words and your mind goes blank. If you can, try and engineer a quick coffee or comfort break. If this is not possible, stay calm and say “Excuse me for a minute while I just think about this..” The audience will not have a problem with this – they like presenters to be human beings (warts and all), not super-slick machines or robots.
2. You are delivering a presentation with a colleague who is doing too much talking and you need to shut him/her up. Try and agree some “code-words” before your presentation so you don’t have to correct your colleague in public. For example, if he/she hears the agreed signal “We’ll come back to that later John” he will know that is actually means “Shut up John!”

3. You switch on your projector and nothing happens. Be prepared to use back-up equipment. For example if the power-point has failed then you will need your handouts or overhead projector slides handy.

HYGIENE FACTORS: These are things which will not motivate people if they are “right” but will de-motivate people if they are wrong. For example, the temperature of the room, the lighting, the ventilation, water on the tables, mints and toffees, pens to write with etc are all “hygiene factors”.

Don’t rely on someone else to check that they are right – make a quick phone call before the presentation to make sure that your audience is going to be in a comfortable environment that will encourage listening and learning, not an environment that will encourage moans and groans.

Try and gain access to the presentation room before you start to carry out a last minute check.

INVOLVEMENT AND PARTICIPATION: If you want people to get involved in your presentation and participate remember to tell them. It is a simple and obvious point but many presenters often feel that their audience was quiet and uninvolved. In many cases the presenter forgot to tell them that he/she wanted them to be active and ask questions.

“If people help plan your battle they won’t battle your plan”

You can also encourage involvement by asking people to chat through an issue with a colleague sat next to them.

If ever you find yourself running a training programme, involvement can be encouraged through quizzes, group work exercises and role-plays etc.

**“I hear, I forget.
I see, I remember.
I do, I understand.”**

JOKES AND HUMOUR: We all know the value of using humour during our work. When presenting to groups of people, however, there are a number of guidelines:-



1. Don’t use humour if it is not your natural style!
2. on’t tell people you are about to tell them a funny story (because they won’t find it funny – it will fall well short of their expectations).

3. Keep your humour safe – nothing politically incorrect. If you start a joke with the words “Have you heard the one about the one-legged black homosexual from Dublin?” you are probably going to upset someone.
4. Make sure that the humour is linked to the presentation in some way. If you tell a joke or funny story that is not linked it will confuse people and they will struggle to see its relevance.
5. Remember that you don’t have to tell jokes – you can be spontaneous and amusing throughout your presentation in many other ways.

KEYWORDS v SCRIPTS: Should you use keywords or should you write the presentation out in full and use a script? There will always be a healthy debate on this subject although if put to a vote the winner would be “keywords”.



Keywords on card or a piece of paper “open the door” to a hundred more words. They act as a natural prompt and encourage the presenter to use a relaxed, warm conversational style.

The keywords should be half an inch tall so that you can read them from a distance of 4-5 feet as you move between your projector, flip chart and audience. Try not to hold them as you will resemble a vicar holding a hymnbook. If you do decide to hold them, remember to only write on one side of your cards.

Another approach you may like to try is the brain-map approach. Use a sheet of A4, plenty of colour and symbols to map out your thought processes.

Scripts are a little dated and suggest that the presenter is going to deliver the presentation regardless of the comments and contributions that come from the floor. They can be viewed as impersonal and mechanical in today’s more relaxed, open-neck business environment.

LISTENING: Presenters concentrate on giving information rather than receiving it. However, if involvement and questions from the audience are desired, listening is a key skill for a presenter.



That is the theory. The reality is often quite different as there are a number of barriers to effective listening:-

Red Rag. Some words are like the proverbial “red rag to a bull”. When we hear them we get upset or irritated and stop listening. We tune in to our feelings and tune out the member of the audience.

Open Ears – Closed Mind. Sometimes we decide rather quickly that either the subject or the speaker is boring. We jump to conclusions and start to predict what he will say next. Our listening ability drops as we have “heard all this before”.

Too-Deep-For-Me. This happens when we are listening to ideas that are too complex or intellectual. Rather than ask questions to clarify and simplify we often say nothing and switch off.

Competitive. We do not like to have our pet ideas, prejudices and points of view overturned. We do not like to be challenged – particularly when presenting as we feel more vulnerable than usual. Consequently, when a member of the audience says something that clashes with what we think and believe we may unconsciously stop listening or even become defensive and plan a counter-attack.

Yes-But. If a member of the audience asks a question and we respond with a “Yes-But” we are dismissing his comments very quickly. Instead of making an attempt to understand his point of view we decide to talk over him and quickly return to what we wanted to say. Try saying “Yes-And”. This suggests that we have listened and can develop the point further by adding another point of view.

Judgemental. Judging the other person often leads to us switching off. How they look, speak and behave can affect our listening skills

Side-stepping. Countering questions with jokes or hollow clichés will irritate the audience.

Appealing to the majority. Sometimes a lone questioner will be in the minority (and we know it!). Rather than answering the question we appeal to the majority and quickly move on.

Guidelines for improving our listening:

- Listen to the content but also listen to the feelings that go with it. If you can then say to the questioner “You sound very concerned about that” or “You are obviously upset by that” it will show that you have really understood the point.
- Listen to what is not said e.g. When Michael Heseltine said “I can see no reason why I should stand for the leadership of the Party” what he really said was “If circumstances change, I will stand for the leadership”.
- Don’t let pressure rush your response – stay calm and say, for example, “Can you give me another thirty seconds on that Ray”. With this additional information you may identify some other issues.
- If you create a group-work exercise or discussion watch for visual clues of interest and commitment – these will help you deal with any questions that come later.
- Listen out for potentially mischievous questions designed to lure you in to politics and controversy e.g. “You must have come across this sort of problem before – what is your view on how it should best be solved?”

- Summarise back to the audience on a regular basis – this is a safe strategy because it makes sure that you have understood their feelings before you move on to your next point.

“A wise old bird sat on an oak, the more he saw the less he spoke, the less he spoke the more he heard, why aren’t we like that wise old bird?”

Edward Hersey Richards

MEETINGS: Meetings get a bad press. For many people the definition of happiness, at the end of a meeting, is hearing that they do not have to meet again!

One study by a management consultancy found that 30% of meetings were a waste of time. They concluded that if a piece of capital equipment was to lie idle for 30% of the time or if people sat twiddling their thumbs for 30% of their time, heads would roll. Yet because people in meetings “look busy” massive losses of productivity are ignored – a classic example of confusing activity with achievement.

However, meetings do have a number of benefits over other forms of communication:-



1. They save us time – something important can be communicated to a group of people much quicker than a series of one-to-ones.
2. Meetings provide an ideal problem-solving and brainstorming environment – creative sparks fly.
3. Good meetings can be very motivational as they provide an opportunity for recognition and praise.
4. For those team members who are motivated by additional responsibility and authority there are opportunities for them to “do a turn” (a presentation or training session perhaps).
5. Meetings provide an opportunity to confirm or deny the grapevine. Policy and grey areas can be defined – people leave the meeting knowing what is happening and what is not happening.
6. Meetings allow people to channel and empty their feelings and emotions. If these feelings stay “bottled” the resulting stress and unnecessary distractions will affect the quality of work. If people empty their feelings and feel as if they have “got things off their chests” they will do a better job.
7. Meetings provide an opportunity for participation and ownership. Team members may often be presented with policy objectives and “destinations” but they should,

where possible, be involved in the construction of the “routes” to the objectives. To put it another way, they may not be able to influence where they are going but they will certainly have some good ideas on how to get there.

8. Meetings are an excellent teambuilding opportunity. They allow groups of disparate individuals to work together towards common goals
9. Meetings are fun – just like other aspects of work!

Here are some tips for running effective meetings:-

- Be clear on your objective for the meeting – ask yourself the questions “What is this meeting supposed to achieve? What do I want people to do as a result of it? How will the success of the meeting be measured? What are the consequences of not holding the meeting?”
- Find out what others want out of the meeting – canvass for agenda suggestions a fortnight before the meeting
- Circulate the agenda a week before the meeting to explain the content, timings, who is attending and who is “performing”. If you expect team members to deliver a short presentation they will need plenty of time to prepare.
- When looking at your list of agenda items try and get them in a logical batting order. Try running AOB first (to get it out of the way) followed by results and figures (which are often dry and tedious) followed by anything controversial (sandwiched in the middle of the meeting) followed by a break (to refresh and renew the team) followed by something participative (to kick-start interest again) finishing with one or two items of great interest (team members will wait for these, rather like a top-of-the-bill cabaret act).
- Remember that there is little value in going around the table asking everyone to comment on their results – it can often be de-motivational and intimidating. This can also be dull and boring – people have a great interest in their own figures and very little interest in others’ figures. Don’t waste time on history.
- Learn from the past but try and concentrate on the future as the team will spend the rest of its life there!
- Remember to brief any guests or VIPs attending and tell people why they are coming.
- Consider the best room layout to achieve the objectives (see Different Room Layouts).
- Get in to the meeting room early to prepare.
- Control the meeting by sticking to the agenda – change the running order only with the consent of the team.
- Don’t have mobile phones on in the room – “if people are going to be in room they should be in the room”.
- Introduce each item in turn, explain the background to it and why it is on the agenda. Be concise, don’t make speeches.
- Ask team members to comment and contribute – try to encourage the quieter members and restrict the dominant members who always want to say something.

- Don't manipulate the meeting with comments or questions like "Firstly, let me tell you what I think we should do! Does anybody violently disagree with my thinking? We don't need to spend too long on this item as I have talked to many of you before the meeting. We will try it my way and change it later if it doesn't work out."
- Remember that the process of decision-making is as important as the outcome of decisions as far as the team members are concerned.
- Ask open-ended questions to open up the meeting e.g. "What do you all think? What other options have we got? Why do you say that John? Where is your evidence for that comment Sue? What do other members of the team think?"
- Thank people for their contributions, even if you disagree with what they have said.
- Don't show favouritism by letting those you agree with have more "airtime" than those you disagree with.
- Have regular breaks
- Express yourself clearly – avoid jargon, in-jokes and references that may only be known to some of the team members.
- Don't give important and unimportant items equal time – prioritise in the time available. There is nothing wrong with saying "We will give this item 30 minutes and if we need more time we will make it "item one" when we next meet".
- Be prepared to share the chairmanship of the meeting – if a team member has contributed a twenty-minute item then maybe they should chair it.
- When trying to persuade team members, use the same skills as a barrister in court – state the proposition, provide the evidence, decide what the evidence means, discuss the verdict and agree the sentence (i.e. the actions to be taken).
- Praise others not yourself. It may seem unfair but do not claim credit for doing things that you are expected to do – like running a good meeting. If compliments are given, accept them graciously.
- Keep calm, even when provoked. Challenge is a healthy sign. A sure sign of a decaying team is the lack of challenge. See challenge as a sign of life and energy. Don't see it as "resistance", see it as "loyal opposition". You never know – their idea might be better than yours.
- Use open-questions to close down the conversation e.g. "What is the action point here then? What should we do now? What other views are there before we try and pull this together? Who would like to summarise what we have agreed on here?"
- Thank all contributors for their efforts
- Try and finish on a high – look to the future with optimism and enthusiasm.

MENTAL IMAGES: When you are presenting hundreds of words try and build powerful mental images for people to visualise.

Example 1. Rather than saying that three important things need to happen in the future you could try saying "Think of this as a three-legged stool – three things are needed and they are all important – a three legged stool will only stand up if all three legs are strong – it will fall over if only two legs are strong."

Example 2. Rather than saying that a number of important pieces of information are needed try saying “Think of this as a jigsaw – we have some pieces of information but we are still missing a number of other pieces of the jigsaw. We need to find these pieces then get round the table again to build the picture on the box.”

MINUTES v ACTION PLANS: Keeping minutes of meetings is a little “dated” in today’s business world. They also tend to be issued long after the meeting, are re-written to protect the guilty and tend to be forgotten but then implemented twenty-four hours before the next meeting.

Compiling a sheet of action points is a better alternative or, in the case of a meeting with a customer or prospect, a “joint action plan” suggests that two organisations are working in a spirit of partnership towards common goals.

Proposed actions should not be ambiguous – they should be SMART – specific, measurable, achievable, relevant and timed.

Action plans can be photocopied at the end of the meeting to allow people to “get on with it” quickly. The typed, or email version, can catch up within the week. Many people in today’s fast-moving, pressurised business world would accept that a good action plan implemented today is better than a perfect action plan implemented next month!

Action?	By whom?	By when?	Comments
Build new product development policy	Richard	End July	Speak to Kath re: support
Produce list of 300 prospects	Sue/Frank	15 August	Marketing have 50 on file
Audit the top ten customers through face to face meetings	Gill to prepare the questions	1 September	MD meeting needed
	Bernie to run meetings	Ten completed end November	Bullet-point conclusions to be circulated

“Don’t keep minutes – they waste hours!”

NARRATIVE: During your presentation try and tell stories from time to time. People find them interesting and enjoyable. They have a logical structure to them (a beginning, middle and end) that builds and builds as time goes by.

OBJECTIONS: If you face a number of objections during your presentation remember the “Three-What” technique. There are three key questions beginning with “what?” followed by “what else?” then “what if?” This technique is soft, sensitive and brings people with you in their own time.

Example:

Customer in the audience: “I’m not sure about this as it all sounds rather expensive”.

You: What exactly do you mean Bill?

Customer: Well, it is a good 20% over our budget!

You: What else is holding us up – is there anything else I need to know?

Customer: Yes, there is actually. We need some reassurance that your company can handle a piece of business this size.

You: So what if I was able to look at our price and bring it closer to your budget and also put you in touch with half a dozen customers who have used us recently would you be happy to go ahead?

Customer: Yes

PERFECTIONISM: This is an illness not a quality. Don’t over-do it. Prepare thoroughly but do what is needed to meet and exceed their expectations (not yours).

PERSONAL BUYING MOTIVATORS: Your audience will “buy” your presentation for a number of different reasons. They will have “technical” needs – i.e. the ability of your product or service to solve a particular problem or meet a specific need and they will have “commercial” needs – i.e. the price, terms, financing and whether or not a return on the investment will be achieved.

However, although they are difficult to spot, it is often the “personal” motivators that determine who wins the day – the audience’s needs for achievement, friendship, influence or security.

If you have people in your audience with a high need for ACHIEVEMENT they like to work with a structured agenda, accomplish more than most, plan for the longer term and agree goals and actions at the end of a presentation or meeting. These people will probably have an office full of certificates and trophies that proudly say “look at me and my achievements!”



In your presentation, try and find something that emphasises something that will allow him/her to beat their competitors. Be clear at all times and build measurable goals into your proposals. A slide of a calendar showing “who will be doing what and when over the next six months” will always be well received.

Some members of the audience will be motivated by FRIENDSHIP in the workplace – the need for warm personal relationships with others. They like to be liked, sacrifice their own needs for the sake of the team, don’t like conflict and smooth over difficulties if they see any problems surfacing in the room. On their office wall will be a company team photograph of the management team on the steps of a smart county hotel or a team event like the company golf day.

Try a little social chat before you start, don’t refuse the offer of teas or coffees and try and win over his/her boss (as they dread the prospect of a disagreement).

Others in your audience will have a high need for INFLUENCE and power. They like to impress, be forceful, name-drop, are often political and devious, are concerned with their reputation, often join organisations outside work where they can have influence, like to control situations and cause strong emotions in the room like fear, anger and delight. When entering their office you will quickly be guided to the photograph on the wall of Richard Branson or The Queen which basically says “look at the important influential people I know”



Ask for agenda suggestions before your presentation, be prepared to change things around so he/she feels in control, let him/her lead the discussions and recognise valuable contributions. When you have a quiet moment, emphasise how your proposals will affect status within the organisation. To put it another way, be prepared to bite your lip and play games. The good news is that these people are so preoccupied with themselves that they won’t spot just how clever you have been!

Finally, your audience will also have a number of people with a high need for SECURITY – the need to feel safe at work. For them, this comes through dealing with financially stable suppliers, avoiding grey areas, dealing with new ideas gradually, avoiding risk and cautiously approaching the future with measured pessimism. These people will have a photograph in their office that makes them feel secure – their partner or family at home.



Try to keep your presentation very “black and white”, make it easy to buy by breaking it down into bite-size pieces, sell the benefits of change, allow plenty of time for questions (and reassurance), be prepared to offer “evidence” of people or organisations that have previously gone ahead with your proposal and praise regularly to encourage further participation and adventure.

To appeal to the personal motivators of these four very different people you will need to see clues that reveal “who they really are”. Do as much preparation as you can before the presentation, ask colleagues for an insight into the character and personalities of your audience and, where possible, ask warm friendly customer contacts for an insight into their colleagues and “what makes them tick”.

PITCH, PACE AND PAUSES: Pitch – try and pitch your voice up one level from normal – put some music in it – this will make your voice carry better and also sound “up” and more motivational.

Pace – slow down when you are about to cover your most important points. Talking quietly will also enhance this technique and your audience will look up and tune in. Speed up your presentation on points requiring action! A louder voice here will enhance and emphasise your points.

Pauses – don’t forget the power of silence. After you have presented a key point that you want your audience to think about or reflect on try pausing for 3-4 seconds before moving on.

POSITIVE THINKING: Don’t undersell yourself and say that you are “fairly good” at something or “reasonable”. Nobody would buy a soap powder if the advert said it would wash clothes “fairly white”. Be positive and confident about your abilities.

PRICE PRESENTATION: If you have to refer to “price” during your presentation avoid negative language like “cost, fee or rate”. There are many more positive alternatives e.g. “*Your investment would be....*” or “*We can supply and deliver that for....*”



Try and present price as a “sandwich” – surround it with the benefits of your proposal.



Example 1. “We can look forward to improved staff motivation and morale and though my proposal will cost the company £20k it will easily produce a return on investment ten times that within the first year.”

Example 2. “Susan, this piece of kit comes with a two-year guarantee, free service for the first three years and for an investment of £965 + vat we can install it and connect it within 48 hours to meet your deadline.”

QUESTIONS: Questions from your audience are, generally speaking, a good sign – they suggest that people are “with you” and are showing an interest. However, many presenters fall at this hurdle because they misunderstand the question, or the motives of the questioner, and respond with a defensive answer that upsets the questioner and alienates the rest of the audience.



There are five main types of question that presenters are asked:-

1. The question they can't answer – don't bluff your way, offer to come back with the answer later
2. The relevant question already covered – thank the questioner (as the question is relevant) and give a quick recap
3. The relevant question not yet covered – thank the questioner but point out that you are only a few minutes away from answering the point. If you have a poor memory you can always ask someone to raise the question again.
4. The irrelevant harmless question – rather than say that the question is irrelevant ask “Bill, I'm struggling a little with the relevance of that point, could you explain what's behind your question?” Now the questioner will probably see that the question is irrelevant and accept your offer to discuss it over coffee during a break rather than hold up the presentation.
5. The irrelevant harmful question – slow down, buy more time by asking for more information. You may like to use subtle peer group pressure by appealing to the rest of the audience by asking “What does everyone else think to Gerry's question?” Hopefully someone will suggest that you move on which will allow you to say something like “Gerry, the message I'm picking up from your colleagues is that I should move on but perhaps we could chat about it later as I can give you some information on that.”

RETENTION OF INFORMATION: Your audience will forget information very quickly. One survey carried out in the eighties concluded that an audience will forget 85% of a presentation after one week! We therefore need a number of tricks and techniques to improve retention of your key points. Using visual material, rather than verbal, will help, of course. Also encouraging the audience to write things down from

time to time or changing their senses and giving them things to play with and handle will improve retention even further.

You can also use Mnemonics and Acronyms with great effect. Mnemonics are “proper words” where each letter conveys a different point to remember.

Example 1. “SMART objectives should be specific, measurable, achievable, relevant and timed.”

Example 2. “OPERA stands for the five stages of effective teamwork – objectives, planning, executing, reviewing and amending.”

Acronyms are “made up words” that do the same job e.g. NATO, UNICEF. One of most commonly used business acronyms is the SWOT Analysis – people will remember (for life) that it stands for an analysis of strengths, weaknesses, opportunities and threats.

RETURN VISITS: Sometimes you will make a second visit to present your solutions to a customer and there will be people present who were not there at the first meeting. This ten-point checklist will be very useful:-

1. Introduce yourself to the new faces.
2. Ask for an explanation of their role
3. Ask how much they know about the first meeting
4. Recap as necessary – summarise “who said what” and what was identified and agreed at the first meeting.
5. Ask if anything has changed since the first meeting
6. Explain your objectives for the second meeting
7. Ask if they have anything they would like to add
8. Consider dealing with their additional comments first
9. Check the time available and any likely interruptions to your presentation
10. Pre-close to check interest and commitment “*If you like my presentation today and agree that it meets your needs where do we go from here? What would the next stage be?*”

SENTENCE CONSTRUCTION: When presenting use sentences that are much shorter than normal. If the sentence is too long your audience will have forgotten your main point by the time you get to the end. Generally speaking, your presentation sentences should contain only one idea and should be about half the length of a written sentence.

SLIDES: Keep these points in mind when designing your slides:-

- Good slides are true visuals, not “visible verbals”. Slides that show diagrams, charts, graphs, cartoons etc are more interesting than row after row of words.
- Keep the slides simple – one slide should convey only one idea otherwise your audience will spend time trying to make sense of it instead of listening to you.
- Do not print anything vertically – it will be too difficult to read
- Have no more than 3-4 lines of bullet-point text
- Don’t use too many visuals – they should punctuate your talk, not dominate it.
- There is no point putting up a slide showing the words that you are actually saying at that time – the slides should show things that actively support and illustrate your words.
- Build-up slides are particularly effective. For example a slide showing a number of “jigsaw pieces” that make the “big picture” or a number of “blocks” that make the “foundations”.
- Use colours "psychologically" i.e. red for danger/problems, green for strengths/solutions.

SPICING UP THE PRESENTATION:

1. Contrasts – this is a very effective technique, often used by politicians in sound-bites. It features two “opposites”. One of the most famous (well rehearsed) contrasts was used by Neil Armstrong when he stepped on to the moon – “one small step for a man, one giant leap for mankind!” Some examples of business presentation contrasts are listed below:-

- You never get a second chance to create a good first impression!
- We have achieved so much with so little!
- We are large enough to cope and small enough to care!
- This will not cost you pennies but it will save you pounds!
- We can’t solve the problems of the future with the solutions of the past!
- Local efforts have failed but the national campaign must succeed”!
- We need to be proactive not reactive!
- Today I have some good news and some bad news!
- These are small changes but they will create big differences!
- Downtime will become up-and-running time!
- We’ve earned our stripes and we are going to knock spots off the competition!
- We can do more with less!



Note the exclamation marks – contrasts have few words but have great impact!

2. Repetition – this technique drums your point home. Repetition was used with great effect by Winston Churchill during the war years and the closing minute of his “beaches” speech is featured below. It repeats the phrase “we shall” with great effect.

“We shall go on to the end, we shall fight in France, we shall fight on the seas and the oceans, we shall fight with growing confidence and strength in the air, we shall defend our island whatever the cost may be, we shall fight on the beaches, we shall fight on the landing grounds, we shall fight on the streets, we shall fight in the hills.....we shall never surrender!”

Some examples of this Repetition technique being used in a business presentation context are listed below:-

We must improve the way we manage it, we must improve the way we monitor it and we must improve the way we measure it!

We must remember the results of this survey, we must remember how our customers feel and we must remember that if we don’t fix these issues we are dead!

3. Three-part lists – this technique uses three tuneful phrases or words:
 - A Mars a day helps you work, rest and play
 - Anytime, anyplace, anywhere
 - There is no conspiracy, complacency or confusion

This technique is particularly powerful on slides – it is simply three big points that will have impact and be remembered:-

*“During the next six months we all need to give more.....
Effort!
Creativity!
Passion!”*

*“We look forward to working with you.....
We have the competence
We have the commitment
We have the confidence”*

Notice how this second example also makes good use of repetition – “We have the” is repeated three times and the three subject words all begin with the letter “C”. The third example is similar in the sense that it repeats the “S” word.

*“I am going to cover three things.....
The survey results
The situation today
The solutions needed”*

The most famous use of all three of these “spicing up the presentation” techniques working together was, once again, Winston Churchill.

***“Is this the end?
Is this the beginning of the end?
No....it is just the
end of the beginning!”***

These twenty short words include repetition (the words “end” and “Is this”), a three-part list and a contrast (beginning of the end and end of the beginning). Some business examples of combining the three techniques are listed below:-

1. “I would like to talk to you this morning about three things – our past, our present situation and our future.”
2. “When you use our services there is one thing I can promise you. You will get tomorrow’s technology today.”
3. “We have successfully developed the promise, we have successfully sold our customers the promise but we have not yet successfully delivered the promise”
4. “We need to reduce our costs, we need to maintain morale and we need to increase customer satisfaction”

TEAM BRIEFING MODEL: Team briefings tend to be short, sharp, informative and motivational. As information cascades through an organisation a template is often needed to ensure that people receive the same information at the same time in the same way.

The model below (believed to have originated from The Industrial Society) has proved to be a very effective way of cascading information from top to bottom and back up again.

PERFORMANCE

Most team briefings have measurements of performance that need to be communicated (company sales performance, comparisons with last year, comparisons with targets, departmental performance, overall Group performance etc)



POLICY

Companies have an ongoing need to reinforce policy and procedure. Topics like health and safety, quality etc are good examples of this. This second part of the team briefing also explains new policies that are being introduced – why the policy is being introduced, how it will work, what individuals are expected to do about it, how progress will be monitored etc.

PEOPLE

“Births, marriages and deaths” of course but also new people who have joined the business, people who have been promoted, people from head office who will be in the building, key suppliers who may be on site etc.

PROBLEMS

Deliberately sandwiched, not left until the end where it could create a negative ending, this section is designed to examine a specific problem the company or department has. It can also be used as a highly interactive brainstorming session by asking the team to identify problems and work together to find and implement solutions.

PLANS

A strong, positive way of ending the team briefing – looking at the plans for the future – talking about the challenges, objectives, actions needed etc.

Like all good plans, this section should be as **SMART** as possible (specific, measurable, achievable, relevant and timed.) For example, rather than saying “the company wants to win some new business in the future” the presenter should say “the company wants to win £500,000 of new business from 10 new customers by the end of September.”

Always try to finish on a “high”. Team briefings are like giant pandas mating – the expectations are high but the results are usually disappointing!

“The leader must have infectious optimism – the final test is the feeling you have just when you leave his or her presence. Do you have a feeling of uplift and confidence?”

Field Marshall Montgomery

TEAM PRESENTATIONS: When working with colleagues always work with the right people, not those who happen to be available. Ask yourself the questions “Who is best qualified to help me achieve the objectives? Who should do what – how should the presentation workload be shared? How can I use the most senior people effectively? How can I shield the most junior members of the team?”

THIRD-PARTY RESEARCH: When presenting, bring your “witnesses to court”. Refer to third parties to support your case e.g. “According to a recent survey by the Institute of Directors.....” or “Last year five key industry trends were identified by the Trade Federation – I would like to go through them and explain some of the implications.....”

TIME MANAGEMENT: Always start on time and definitely finish on time or you will “lose” people if you over-run.

“Watch your watch – short presentations are not always the best but

the best presentations are always short!"

Most people will listen and watch attentively for 30-40 minutes before they need a break. If this is not possible try changing the senses – if your audience has listened to you for some time consider an exercise or group discussion to maintain and stimulate interest.



UNDERSTANDING BODY LANGUAGE SIGNALS: There are some excellent books available on this subject, particularly those written by an Australian writer, Alan Pease. However, as a general rule, you are looking for “clusters” of body language signals not just one and “congruence” i.e. are the words and body saying the same things?

SIGNAL	PROBABLE MEANING
Furrowed forehead	Negative thoughts or concentration
Tapping foot	Impatience, irritation
Avoiding eye contact	Anxiety, suspicion, confusion, shyness
Scratching, pinching or pressing	Punishing self or wants to punish another
Clenching fists	Holding back anger
Finger jabbing	Criticism
Arms folded, legs crossed	Putting up defence barriers
Hand covering mouth	Hiding, playing games, yawning
Physical stroking of face	Comforting self
Intense eye contact	Anger or concern

If, during your presentation, you detect someone in the audience looking confused, upset or angry don't ignore them. You could deal with the problem there and then by saying “Bill, you look a little confused.....” or you could have a word during a coffee break.

“No news is good news” is a potentially dangerous theory for presenters – silence can often mean disagreement, confusion and lack of commitment. “No news is worrying” is a much safer theory to have because it will encourage you to explore and resolve any body language concerns you may have.

VISUAL AIDS: These are excellent for changing the senses during your presentation but if you are going to use visual aids there are number of guidelines:-

- keep it/them out of sight until needed otherwise they will become a distraction
- when introducing a visual aid give it a “trumpet fanfare” before producing it
- remove it after you have used it otherwise it will (again) become a distraction
- if you are going to use handouts make sure that you have one copy for each person.

WINDING UP WITH IMPACT: A presentation is like a love affair – anyone can start it but to end it requires considerable skill. Many presenters do a fantastic job during their presentation then finish on a low note by saying “...err, well that’s it really, I’ve got nothing else to say, ...err thanks,thanks for listening.....err that’s it!”

The presentation needs to finish with impact with some well crafted and structured content.

- Firstly, recap on your original (three?) objectives to remind the audience what you set out to achieve – this is probably the only slide that will appear twice.
- Then recap on the main points of your presentation – the main thrust of your argument.
- Thank them for their input and questions then, before your grand-finale big ending, ask if anyone has any final questions before you summarise.
- Having cleared the way, use the sound-bite techniques of contrasts, repetition and three-part lists to finish on a high.

During the last forty minutes I have attempted to explain the background to the customer research I have carried out, the results and actions we must now take.	Recap on your objectives with original slide
The message, ladies and gentlemen, is clear. As an organisation we do not yet exceed our customers' expectations. According to my research, more than 50% of our customers think we struggle to meet their expectations and well over 20% of customers think that we fall well short of their expectations.	Recap on your main points – use third party facts and figures to back your claims
I would like to thank you all for your time, your input and thought-provoking questions. I would particularly like to thank Sheila for the time spent with me during the research and Frank for his help with the slides.	Thanks where appropriate.
Before I summarise does anyone have any final questions? No.....	Final questions – quick check
.....so perhaps I could leave you with some thoughts • We have developed the dream for the future • We have successfully sold the dream for the future • We have not yet delivered the dream for the future – for many of our customers today our dream is their nightmare! * Let's all look forward to a day when these issues have been fixed. * Let's all look forward to the year when we are regarded as world leaders in customer service. * But let's all start today by working together effectively as a united T.E.A.Mtogether everyone achieves more! Thank you.	Contrasts, repetition and three-part lists Grand-finale ending again using contrasts, repetition and three-part lists plus a mnemonic to encourage retention of information

The last couple of minutes is, of course, key to the success of your presentation – remember that what you say last will be remembered first. The golden rule here is give the audience something to remember you by!

WRITTEN PROPOSALS: If you are presenting to customers or prospects they will often expect a written proposal – not necessarily “war and peace” but a 5-10 page summary of your presentation.

Written proposals make customers feel reassured – they convert our “unofficial” promises into something that is “black and white” and has the full weight and support of our company.

The proposal may also help you reach key decision makers and influencers who were off-site at the time of your presentation. If your presentation contains complicated or technical data the written proposal will allow the reader to “re-read” your recommendations so that they can absorb the information in their own time.

25% of people learn mainly through reflection – these “reflectors” need a vehicle to help them reflect and digest your words of wisdom.

Sadly many written proposals look standard, rarely refer to the customer, are full of padding, are dull and too factual, feature too much written English, look as if they were produced by a machine and suggest “this is going to cost you lots of money”.

Here are the main points to remember if you are going to use a written proposal to support your presentation:-

- Invest the time needed to create the right impression. Think about using customer logos (with their permission) on the front cover and a theme that the customer will relate to.
- Make sure that names and titles are correct – Jon Wylkes, Marketing Director will not react favourably to being called John Wilkes, Director of Marketing.
- Use colour, graphs, charts and other interesting visuals
- Date the proposal and number the pages
- Consider the use of digital camera shots
- Avoid outdated clichés like “thank you for the courtesy extended to myself during my recent visit”. Golden rule – write it as you would say it i.e. spoken English not written English.

Written English	Spoken English
I am in receipt of	Thanks for
In regard to	About
The undersigned	We
Will you be so kind as to	Could you
In the event that	If
As per our agreement	As agreed
In the normal course of events	Usually
At the present time of writing	Today
At a later date	Later
I want to say that it was a pleasure	I enjoyed
I myself personally	I

- Tailor your proposal to the customer's situation – refer back to previous meetings and quote people, where appropriate, using italics e.g. “I was interested to learn about your plans for the future which will “take the company into the Premier league” or “I have noted your concerns about “suppliers not adding value to your business”.
- Adjust the level of language to meet the intellectual needs of the audience/readers – the Sun reader will usually not appreciate Financial Times language and vice-versa.
- Don't sound like a mass – produced mailshot – build in your character e.g. “Dear Bill, I enjoyed our meeting on Thursday – it was great to see you again” or “I will bring the proposal with me when we meet again on 17 March – in the meantime, have a good holiday.”
- Ask yourself the question “is my proposal bound to impress or is it bound for the bin?” (I think that's called a contrast!).
- Say if your proposal goes out of date.

X-TRA THINGS TO DO LATER:

- Pack up your kit and leave the venue looking clean and tidy.
- Remove any handouts (you don't want them falling into the hands of your competitors) and any confidential flip chart pages. Offer to get the pages “typed up” so their removal does not appear to be strange or unnecessary.
- If you have just delivered a presentation to a customer you may want to reflect on the % probability of the business coming your way. Ask yourself “What is the % probability now and what do I have to do to make it 100% probable?”

To help with the objective assessment of the probability the checklist below can be quite useful. It has ten criteria that affect the probability – if each scores 10% you can score yourself very easily. (Change the numbers if you feel that the scores should be weighted.)

CRITERIA	10% FOR EACH IF PRESENT
1. Did I present to all of the decision makers and influencers?	
2. Did I identify the needs accurately?	
3. Was my presentation tailored to meet those needs?	
4. Were any objections or problems openly discussed?	
5. Is their decision-making process free from company politics?	
6. Is our price right?	
7. Have we got the ability and experience to deliver the solution?	
8. Have we got the upper hand over our competitors?	
9. Have I effectively explained benefits v costs?	
10. Are they making the right positive noises towards us?	
TOTAL OUT OF 100	? %

- If, during your presentation, you answered any questions with the words “I will come back to you on that” make sure that you say something within 48 hours. If you forget to do this you may be perceived as someone who “dodged the question”.
- Amend your notes in the light of any comments and suggestions made by the audience.
- Send an email to thank the organiser, the IT person who helped with your slides or anyone who deserves a “mention in dispatches”.
- Keep on their desks – send something a week or so later. If there are a number of outstanding action points your timely and polite letter, handout, product samples, article or email will help to re-activate the decision-making process.

YOUR ONGOING DEVELOPMENT: A brief A-Z booklet cannot turn you into a brilliant speaker – only practice can do that. Don’t wait for months to go by before you deliver another presentation – push yourself to keep doing them at every available opportunity.

- Consider doing a presentation at internal meetings rather than just chatting through issues in an informal manner.
- Find friendly customers to practice a new presentation in a supportive, low-risk environment.
- Think of clubs and committees outside work – perhaps there is an opportunity to deliver a short presentation at the rugby club, PTA or political club.

ZERO-TEN EVALUATION: Get some critical feedback on your presentation. Ask people to comment on your content, your style, the duration, the quality of any materials used, the way that you handled questions from the audience, the interest level etc.

Don't forget to ask about the joining instructions, venue and facilities if under your control.

Talk to people face to face or use an evaluation form to ask them:

“What was the most useful aspect of my presentation?”

“What was the least useful aspect?”

“How many marks out of ten would you give it?”

“What would I have to do to score ten?”

“How could my presentation have been improved?”

“What did you get out of it – what actions will you now take?”

“What might prevent you from taking these actions?”

Also ask yourself:

“Did I achieve my objective?”

“If not, why not?”

“If I could put the clocks back what could I have done differently?”

“How many marks out of ten.....etc etc?”

"What have I learned from this?"

If you worked with a colleague during the presentation ask for feedback on your contribution and then give feedback on theirs.

ZZZZZZ: A sound you will never hear during your presentations, meetings and briefings. You will be running board-level sessions not bored-level sessions!

For more information visit www.philjesson.com